



COVER
STORY

MASTERS OF MUTILATION

Nehru and Patel insisted on Partition while the sole spokesman of India's Muslims tried to avoid such a catastrophe till the very end

■ By **AYESHA JALAL**

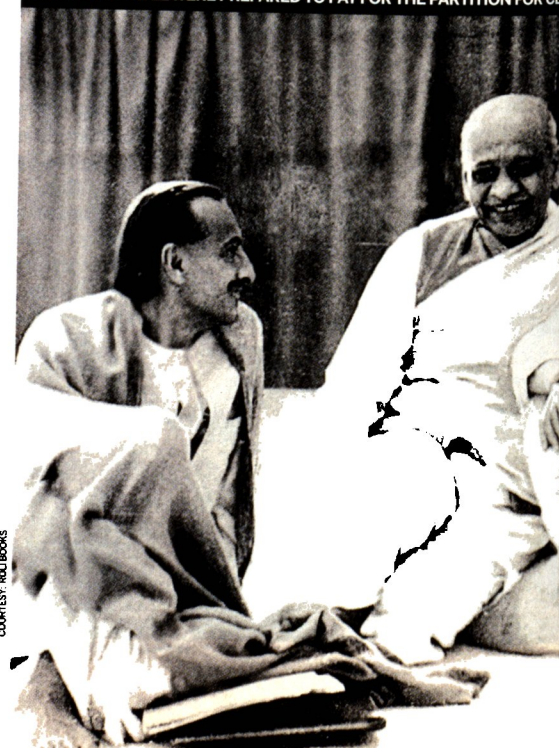
Whether you are Hindus, Muslims, Parsis or Christians," Jinnah said in April 1942 to journalists in Allahabad, "all I can say to you is that, however much I am criticised, however much I am attacked and today I am charged with hate in some quarters, I honestly believe that *the day will come when not only Muslims but this great community of Hindus will also bless, if not during my lifetime, after I am dead, the memory of my name.*" That day may not have quite dawned yet, but the reassessment of Jinnah by top Hindu leaders in India suggests the day may not be far off.

Historians are unlikely to find anything dramatically new in Jaswant Singh's recent book on Jinnah. What is new is a top BJP leader's acceptance of an interpretation of Jinnah's role in South Asian history that is now generally accepted by scholars. Nearly a quarter of a century ago I had shown in my book *The Sole Spokesman*, based on a study of then newly available archival sources, that there was a disjunction between Jinnah's aims and the final outcome of Partition in August 1947. Jinnah had wanted an equitable share of power for India's Muslims, not a partition based on the agonising dismemberment of Punjab and Bengal. Far from hating Hindus, he was opposed only to a version of Congress majoritarianism that showed scant respect for difference. Nehru and Patel, despite their other ideological disagreements, both wanted power at the helm of a centralised state created by the British Raj. Jinnah, by contrast, believed that at the moment of the British withdrawal the unitary centre fashioned by the colonial masters should stand dissolved and a new Union of India created through negotiation among its constituent units. In the context of 1947, these units might have been Hindustan representing the Hindu-majority provinces and Pakistan representing the Muslim-majority provinces, each with substantial minorities whose rights would be fully protected.

Once the all-India negotiations failed to make headway and the Hindu Mahasabha had called for

the division of the two main Muslim-majority provinces of Punjab and Bengal in early 1947, Nehru and Patel insisted on partition; the sole spokesman of India's Muslims tried to avoid such a catastrophe till the very end. Partition could have been averted had the Congress been prepared to cede more power to the provinces and give an adequate share of power to the Muslim League at a federal centre. In the end, Nehru and Patel in their different ways were prepared to pay the price of dividing the motherland for centralised power in a unitary state after exiling a maimed, mutilated and moth-eaten Pakistan to the northwestern and eastern extremities of the subcontinent. If Jaswant's book helps bring into public discourse what scholars have known for some time, he

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